Yet Medina Sidonia had lost only two major ships in the course of the run up the Channel. *Nuestra Senora del Rosario* was damaged in a collision and snapped up by the indisciplined Drake as his personal prize, and *San Salvador* was destroyed by an unexplained explosion. Philip's great "Enterprise of England" fell apart not because of the efforts of the English sailors, but because the intended coordination with the Duke of Parma's army in the Netherlands never happened. The Duke informed Medina Sidonia on arrival that he did not have the barges ready with which to ferry his troops to England.

With no suitable harbor at its disposal, the Armada was left waiting in the exposed Calais roads. At a council on board Howard's flagship *Ark Royal*, the English captains agreed upon a night attack using fireships. It was a familiar tactic and the Spanish had a screen of boats with grapnels—barbed anchors—prepared to haul the burning hulks off course. The British, however, were helped that night by a stiff wind and a following tide, and most of the eight blazing ships bore down into the anchorage. Although not a single Spanish ship was set on fire, panic seized the fleet and ships slipped their cables, fleeing in disorder in the darkness.



Relic of an Armada wreck
This Spanish mariner's astrolabe was found on Valentia Island off the west coast of Ireland, where three Armada ships are known to have been wrecked.

The following morning, August 8, found the ships of the Armada scattered northward off Gravelines, between Calais and Dunkirk, and pressed toward dangerous shoals by an onshore wind. The English, led by Drake's squadron, sailed into the attack while Medina Sidonia gallantly marshaled a defensive formation. The cannon fire was, according to one observer, "the greatest that was even seen or imagined." The Spanish could not match their opponents' rate of fire and were again given no chance to board, although the fighting was often within musket range. The flagship *San Martin* was especially hard hit, with shot tearing the rigging and sails, holing the hull, and killing and wounding many on board. The galleons *San Mateo* and *San Felipe* were so badly shot up that they had to be run aground. Most of the other Spanish front-line fighting ships were damaged, although only the armed merchantman *Maria Juan* was actually sunk by cannon fire.

AFTERMATH OF THE BATTLE

The English broke off the battle after about nine hours, because they were running low on ammunition and confident that the battered Spanish were facing imminent catastrophe, as a rising gale drove them inexorably toward the shoals. The following morning, however, the wind veered as if by miracle and blew the Armada clear into the North Sea. Howard shadowed them as far as the Firth of Forth before turning back, short of supplies and with rapidly sickening crews. Medina Sidonia decided to return to Spain by sailing around the north of Scotland and down the west coast of Ireland.

For English sailors the aftermath of the fighting was a disillusioning experience. Kept in service in case the Armada returned, they were unpaid and short of food, adequate clothing, and shelter. Thousands of them died of epidemic diseases. The fate of the Spanish was worse. Freak storms turned their voyage home into a naval catastrophe. Ships disappeared without trace in the ocean or were wrecked upon the wild Irish coast. Those who survived experienced extremes of deprivation and exhaustion. Just 67 ships out of the original fleet of 130 succeeded in returning to Spanish shores, most of them limping to the port of Santander, where they were repaired and refitted.



Gravelines
This dramatic representation of the battle was painted in 1796, at a time when England again faced the threat of invasion by sea, this time from Revolutionary France. It shows the scene in the early morning after the English fireship attack, with the prow of a Spanish ship silhouetted against the flames.